

Boundaries Masterlist

To do boundaries, you must know:

- 1.) Independent vs Dependent clauses
- 2.) Subjects, verbs, and direct objects
- 3.) Conjunctions and prepositions
- 4.) Functional equivalence
- 5.) The three rules
- 6.) What punctuations do

Must memorize:

All coordinating conjunctions

For And Nor But Or Yet So

Common subordinating conjunctions

As	Because	If	Since	Though	While	That
Which	Where	When	Why	What	How	Who
Whom	Whose					

Common prepositions

As	At	By	For	From	In	Like
Of	On	To	Up	With		

1. Clauses

Independent Clauses

A group of words made up of a **subject (nouns)** and a **predicate (verbs)**. Independent clauses can stand alone because they do not have a **subordinating conjunction**.

Ex.

1. **he** **likes** books
2. the **cat** **woke** up
3. the **sun** **shines** brightly
4. **she** **borrowed** from the library

Dependent Clauses

A group of words made up of a **subject** and a **predicate** that normally begins with a **subordinating conjunction**. It is grammatically incomplete and cannot stand alone

Ex.

1. (I did not know) **that** **he** **likes** books
2. **when** the **cat** **woke** up, (it yawned and stretched)
3. **if** the **sun** **shines** brightly, (the flowers will bloom)
4. (The book), **which** **she** **borrowed** from the library, (was interesting)

Tricky cases (**hidden subordinating conjunctions**):

- 1.) The flowers I planted were growing strong
- 2.) The movie that I knew she loved was a rom-com

Common **Subordinating Conjunctions**:

-As
-Because
-If
-Since
-Though
-While
-That
-Which
-Where
-When
-Why
-What
-How
-Who
-Whom
-Whose

Relative Pronouns can act as a **subject**

2. Subjects, Verbs, and Direct Objects

Subjects are who/what performs the action

Ex. **Nouns**

Robert is my tutor

Ex. **Pronouns**

It is Saturday

Ex. **Relative pronouns**

That is cool

Ex. **Gerunds (nouns that look like verbs)**

Reading is fun

Verbs are the action performed

Ex. **Main verbs**

I **think** so

It **is** Saturday

I **have** to leave

The following are **verbs**:

-is	-are
-has	-have
-was	-were
-do	-does

Ex. **Complex verbs**

I **am thinking** of a number between one and ten

I **can go** to the movies

I **would** not **have** just **been yelling** if it wasn't so loud

I **had had** one of those before they were cool

The following act as
adverbs when near
verbs:

-not
-so
-just
-also

Direct objects are who/what the action is performed on

Ex. Nouns

Robert is my **tutor**

Ex. Relative pronouns

That is **what** I wanted to do

Ex. Gerunds (nouns that look like verbs)

I started **running**

3. Conjunctions and Prepositions

Coordinating conjunctions

Co + ordinal → “ordered with”

Coordinating conjunctions always conjoin two things of the same kind:

- 1) Two independent clauses (need a comma)

I laughed, and you cried

- 2) Two of the same parts of speech

- Nouns
cats and dogs
- Pronouns
he and she
- Verbs
laughing and crying
- Adjectives
black and blue
- Adverbs
quickly and quietly
- Articles
the birds and the bees
- Conjunctions
when she left and where she went
- Prepositions
over the fence and through the woods

- 3) Two of the same parts of a sentence

- **Subjects** → what performs the actions
- **Verbs** → the action
- **Direct objects** → what the action is performed on
- **Indirect objects** → what the action is performed for

You and **I** **wrote** and **recited** a **story** and a **poem** for our **mother** and **father**

Why does this matter? Whenever you see a coordinating conjunction, figuring out what two things it conjoins is often essential to solving a question.

Subordinating conjunctions

Sub + ordinal → “ordered below”

Subordinating conjunctions always conjoin two things of different kinds. This only refers to dependent clauses

Ex. Simple

I went to sleep **because** I was tired

If you want to ace the SATs, you should study your vocabulary

Ex. Relative pronouns

I did not know **what** I was doing

I saw **that** he left

I know **where** he went and **what** he was doing

Ex. Hidden conjunctions (simple)

I knew she left → I knew (**that**) she left

I swear I left it right here → I swear (**that**) I left it right here

Ex. Hidden Conjunctions (complex)

The book I left on the table I bought from the store I visited yesterday was the one I loved the most

Find verbs first:

The book I left on the table I bought from the store I visited yesterday was the one I loved the most

Each verb needs a subject:

The book I left on the table I bought from the store I visited yesterday was the one I loved the most

Hidden conjunctions:

The book (that) I left on the table (that) I bought from the store (that) I visited yesterday was the one (that) I loved the most

Identify dependent clauses:

The book (that) I left on the table (that) I bought from the store (that) I visited yesterday was the one (that) I loved the most

You are left with a complete independent clause

The book was the one

Prepositions

Prepositions are to prepositional phrases as subordinating conjunctions are to dependent clause: they introduce them. Prepositional phrases are used to describe things in the same way that adjectives and adverbs do.

Why does this matter? since prepositional phrases act as descriptors, *nouns and verbs inside them CANNOT act as subjects or predicates*

Prepositional phrases can be used to describe a number of things, most commonly:

1.) **Where** something is

On the table → the computer is on the table

Over there → the door is over there

2.) **When** something takes place

In the morning → In the morning, I woke up

After lunch → We went for a walk after lunch

3.) **How** something is

With confidence → She spoke with confidence

Under pressure → He worked under pressure

4.) **Why** something is

Because of traffic → We were late because of traffic

Due to rain → the picnic was canceled due to rain

5.) **What kind** something is

Of magnesia → I took milk of magnesia

As a student → As a student, I like my classes

6.) **who/what** something belongs to

Of her walls → The color of her walls is beige

For the officers → the donuts are for the officers

4. Functional equivalence

If two answer choices mean the exact same thing, then both answers are wrong.

Overview:

Periods and Semicolons

- 1.) If you have both a period and a semicolon in two answers doing the same thing, then the PERIOD is wrong.
- 2.) If there is no complex list, then the SEMICOLON is also wrong.

Colons and Dashes

- 1.) If you have both a colon and a dash in two answers doing the same thing, then the COLON is wrong.
- 2.) If there is no other dash that needs to be closed in the text, then the DASH is also wrong.

NOTE This rule works in any test where you can only pick 1 answer choice per question.

Ex.

$$\sqrt[3]{216} = \underline{\hspace{2cm}}$$

- A. 7
- B. $\frac{14}{2}$
- C. $\sqrt{49}$
- D. 6

Periods and Semicolons

All three can combine two independent clauses; therefore, two answers choices which contain them can be functionally equivalent (and, therefore, wrong).

Ex.

The children insisted on playing _____ until the sky turned completely dark.

- A. outside.
- B. outside;
- C. outside,
- D. outside

Ex.

The painting, which was created in the 18th _____ is now on display at the museum.

- A. century,
- B. century. It
- C. century; it
- D. century

NOTE: semicolons perform other functions (complex lists), so the mere presence of both answer choices only immediately eliminates the period. If and only if there is no complex list, then they are functionally equivalent.

Not functional equivalence

Two answer choices can only be functionally equivalent if they mean the exact same thing. Simply having the punctuation in the answer choices doesn't matter if they express different meanings.

Ex.

- A. of you as
- B. of. You as
- C. of you; as
- D. of you, as

Choice B and C are in different positions in the sentence

B and C are not functionally equivalent

Ex.

- A. bed he went
- B. bed. When he went
- C. bed; he went
- D. bed, he went

Choice B creates a dependent clause with the **subordinating conjunction** “when”
Choice C creates an independent clause

B and C are not functionally equivalent

Colons and dashes

Both can introduce explanatory information; therefore, they can be functionally equivalent in such cases.

Ex.

He ended _____ losing the race—which he didn't care about anyways.

- A. up,
- B. up:
- C. up—
- D. up

5. The Three Rules

Rule 1.) If you have only ONE answer choice that can combine two independent clauses, then you should find the independent clauses.

Independent clauses must always be separated with either a **period**, a **semicolon**, a **colon**, or a **comma + coordinating conjunction**.

. ; : , and

Ex. Simple

I wanted to go for a _____ it started raining.

- A. walk,
- B. walk
- C. walk, but
- D. walk but

Ex. Complex

What the strange object that had fallen from space could be had been unknown to anyone who had seen _____ conjecturing about what it was was, nonetheless, partaken of by all.

- A. it
- B. it;

- C. it yet
- D. it,

Ex. Complex

Early that evening, his mother, who had been having a rather dreadful morning – on a quite cold and dreary day in early spring – decided, of her own accord, to bake a pie filled to the brim with blueberries for her son, who had become increasingly surly in his _____ even though she made it with love, her son, begrudgingly, had, in a moment of youthful naivety, decided – against his father’s careful recommendation – to loudly and boldly complain that he did not like blueberries, inviting a fury like no other to be brought upon himself.

- A. adolescence
- B. adolescence but
- C. adolescence,
- D. adolescence, but

Rule 2.) Two words in the same phrase/clause cannot be separated with any SINGLE punctuation mark.

NOTE Commas in a list are exceptions to this rule.

NOTE Pay attention to verbs appearing directly after the boundary

Ex. Simple clauses

The determined _____ continued their journey up the mountain.

- A. hikers
- B. hikers,
- C. hikers:
- D. hikers;

Ex. Simple phrases

The book _____ the table is mine.

- A. on,
- B. on—
- C. on
- D. on.

Ex. Complex

Our tutor taught us what rules we need to know in order to ace _____ we should apply them.

- A. the SAT, and when
- B. the SAT, and, when
- C. the SAT and, when
- D. the SAT and when

Ex. Complex

For as long as I can remember, the first time I rode a _____ had always been a terrifying possibility to me, had, after having mustered the courage to ride one, been an exhilarating experience.

- A. rollercoaster
- B. rollercoaster, which
- C. rollercoaster. It
- D. rollercoaster,

Rule 3.) Anything is essential if and only if it specifies exactly what it modifies is referring to.

NOTE Nonessential phrases must be surrounded by punctuation (typically commas)

Ex.

I remember the _____ when we met at the park.

- A. day,
- B. day
- C. day.
- D. day:

Ex. Which (always nonessential)

She finally finished the _____ which took longer than expected.

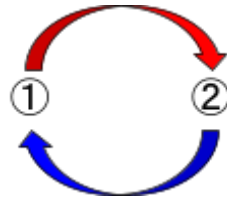
- A. project
- B. project;
- C. project,
- D. project:

Ex. That (always essential)

She finally finished the _____ that took longer than expected.

- E. project
- F. project;
- G. project,
- H. project:

Appositives also require essential/nonessential rules. An appositive is when idea ① is idea ② and idea ② is idea ①



Ex. Essential appositives

_____ taught us about mental disorders.

- A. Psychology professor, Jane Doe
- B. Psychology professor, Jane Doe,
- C. Psychology professor Jane Doe,
- D. Psychology professor Jane Doe

Ex. Nonessential appositives

My _____ taught us about mental disorders.

- A. psychology professor, Jane Doe
- B. psychology professor, Jane Doe,
- C. psychology professor Jane Doe,
- D. psychology professor Jane Doe

Ex.

At the zoo, we learned that _____ have mammary glands that secrete milk directly onto their skin.

- A. monotremes, an order of mammals including the platypus and echidnas
- B. monotremes an order of mammals including the platypus and echidnas,
- C. monotremes—an order of mammals including the platypus and echidnas—
- D. monotremes an order of mammals including the platypus and echidnas

Periods

Possible Uses:

1.) Separate complete thoughts (i.e. independent clauses)

Ex.

The sun was setting _____ the sky turned a brilliant shade of orange.

Ex.

Although the storm raged outside with deafening thunder and blinding lightning, I remained inside by the fireplace, sipping tea and reading a novel _____ my dog slept peacefully beside me, undisturbed by the chaos beyond the windows.

Ex.

The old mansion, which had stood for centuries with its ivy-covered walls and towering spires, creaked and groaned in the howling wind _____ the determined historian continued his research, undeterred by the eerie sounds echoing through the halls.

Commas

Possible Uses:

- 1.) Replace a period, but only when followed by a coordinating conjunction (i.e. FANBOYS)

The coordinating conjunctions are:

-For	-And
-Nor	-But
-Or	-Yet
-So	

Ex.

The rain poured relentlessly, flooding the streets _____ the wind howled through the trees, bending them nearly to the ground.

Ex.

The professor explained the complex theory with clarity, ensuring every student grasped the intricate details _____ the students, though exhausted from hours of lectures, eagerly took notes, determined to understand every concept before the upcoming test.

2.) Separate non-essential information from essential information

The way to determine if something is essential or nonessential is to determine if it specifies the exact meaning of what it describes.

Ex.

The ancient oak tree _ with its gnarled branches reaching toward the sky _ stood proudly in the center of the park.

Ex.

The book _ which I borrowed from the library yesterday _ was surprisingly engaging.

Ex.

The book _ that I borrowed from the library yesterday _ was surprisingly engaging.

Ex.

My brother _ a talented musician _ played the guitar at the concert last night.

Ex.

The dog ran around the yard in excitement _ barking loudly at the mailman.

3.) Separate non-independent clauses at the beginning of the sentence

Ex. Prepositional phrases

After the storm _____ the sky cleared and the sun began to set.

Ex. Dependent clauses

Although she was tired _____ Maria decided to go for a walk in the park.

Ex. Present participle phrases

Running late for the meeting _____ he skipped breakfast and hurried out the door.

Ex. Past participle phrases

Exhausted from the long journey _____ they collapsed into bed as soon as they arrived home.

Ex. Transitions

However _____ the project was completed on time despite the numerous challenges they faced.

4.) Separate items in a simple list

Ex.

For the picnic, we packed sandwiches ____ chips, fruit, and lemonade.

Ex.

We spent the afternoon hiking through the forest ____ swimming in the lake, and enjoying a peaceful picnic by the shore.

Ex.

She enjoyed the book that I recommended ____ the movie which we watched last night, and the cake that we baked together.

Semi-colons

Possible Uses:

1.) Replace a period

Ex.

The scientist meticulously recorded every detail of the experiment, adjusting variables with precision and care _____ her assistant, distracted by a sudden power fluctuation, nearly knocked over a beaker filled with a volatile substance.

Ex.

The orchestra played a hauntingly beautiful symphony that echoed through the grand concert hall _____ the audience sat in mesmerized silence, hanging onto every note as if it were a whispered secret.

2.) Separate items in a complex list

Ex.

After spending the entire day exploring the city, we visited a historic museum filled with ancient artifacts, intricate sculptures, and detailed paintings _____ enjoyed a delicious dinner at a cozy Italian restaurant with handmade pasta, wood-fired pizza, and rich tiramisu; and finally ended the night with a peaceful stroll along the river, admiring the shimmering lights, gentle waves, and cool evening breeze.

Ex.

For the science fair, she built a model volcano, which erupted with a mix of baking soda and vinegar _____ a solar system display with rotating planets; and a circuit board that powered a small lightbulb.

Colons

Possible Uses:

1.) Introduce explanatory information

Note: There will always be an independent clause before the colon

Ex. Dependent clauses

She had one important decision to make ____ whether to accept the job offer in another city.

Ex. Independent clauses

He was determined to succeed ____ failure was not an option.

Note: Colons can replace a period but only if the second independent clause is an explanation for the first

Ex. Lists

He had three main goals for the trip ____ relax, explore new places, and try new foods.

Ex. Grammatically incomplete fragments

She had one passion ____ painting.

Dashes

Possible Uses:

1.) Replace a comma (only usage 2)

Ex.

My neighbor _ who travels frequently for work _ just returned from a trip to Italy.

Ex.

The movie _ which received rave reviews _ won several awards at the film festival.

Ex.

She finished the project on time _ despite the many challenges she faced.

Ex.

The teacher _ who brought several books, a notebook, and a pen _ was ready to start the lesson.

Ex.

The conference _ which featured guest speakers, workshops, and networking events _ was a huge success.

2.) Replace a colon

Ex.

She had only one choice _____ leave the party early or face the consequences.

Ex.

He packed everything for the trip _____ clothes, toiletries, and a camera.